

Slav and Semi-Slav

A Slow Slav repertoire built on development and recurring plans

THE PROMISE

Meet Black's resilient ...c6 structure without drowning in forcing theory, while retaining enough bite to create real problems.

COURSE VOLUME 03 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Use 3.Nf3 and 4.e3 as the stable move-order foundation against the Slav.
- Handle the active ...Bf5 bishop with Nh4 at the right moment.
- Meet the Semi-Slav with b3, Bb2, and Bd3 rather than entering the sharpest Meran and Botvinnik memory contests.
- Recover c4 safely when Black captures, and recognize Triangle transpositions.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

01	The Slow Slav spine
02	The ...Bf5 bishop
03	Black chooses ...Bg4
04	Chebanenko Slav with ...a6
05	Anti-Meran with 5.b3
06	Semi-Slav central break
07	Black captures on c4
08	Triangle move orders

Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

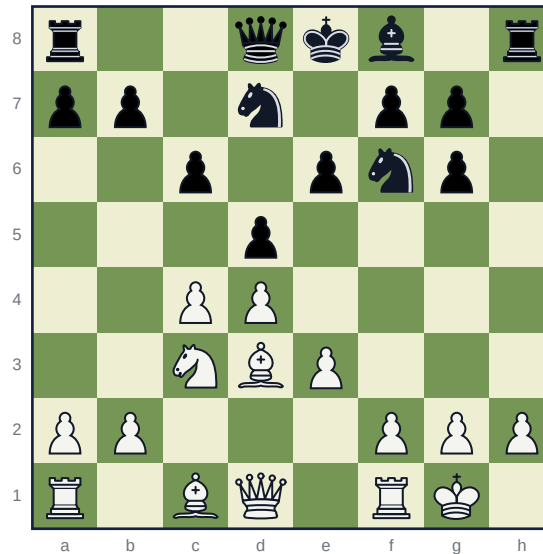
The Slow Slav spine

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6: Black supports d5 without enclosing the c8 bishop.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 Bf5 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nh4 Bg6 7. Nxg6 hxg6 8. Bd3 Nbd7 9. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The Slow Slav declines the immediate theoretical fight over c4 and builds a sound center. White develops Nf3 before Nc3 so ...dxc4 can be met by e3 and Bxc4 without blocking the bishop. When Black's bishop reaches f5 and the center is stable, Nh4 challenges it. Exchanging the bishop can give White the bishop pair and leave Black with a slightly awkward g-pawn, but only if White does not fall behind in development.

White's plan

- Develop Nf3, e3, Nc3, and Bd3; castle before making a second positional operation.
- Use Nh4 when the bishop lacks a useful retreat or when Nxg6 damages Black's kingside structure.
- Prepare e4 if Black is passive; otherwise use queenside space with Qc2, b3, and Bb2.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Bf5 develops the traditionally difficult bishop before ...e6.
- ...Nbd7 supports ...e5 and helps Black complete development.
- ...dxc4 may gain time against the bishop if White delays recovery too long.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Bf5	5.Nc3 e6 6.Nh4 challenges the bishop after the center is secure.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...e6	5.b3: use the Anti-Meran setup in the Semi-Slav chapters.
4...dxc4	5.Bxc4. Development recovers the pawn naturally.
4...g6	5.Nc3 Bg7 6.Bd3; build and prepare e4.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not play Nh4 before Nc3 when ...Bxb1 or ...e5 gives Black a tactical escape. Challenge the bishop after your center and queenside are stable.

MEMORY HOOK

Nf3 and e3 build; Nc3 makes Nh4 safe; then ask the bishop.

CHAPTER 02

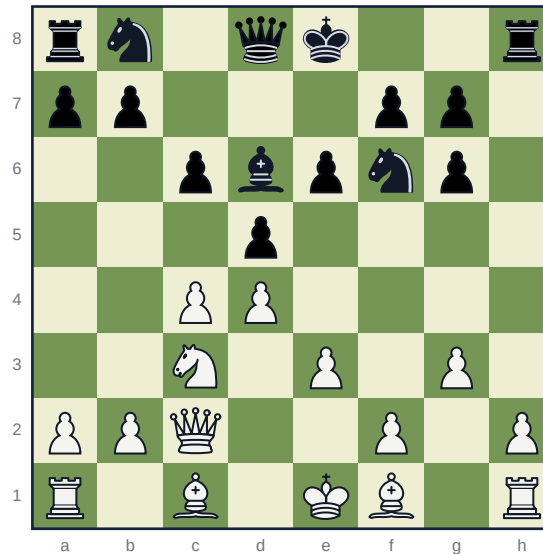
The ...Bf5 bishop

POSITION TRIGGER

Black has developed Bf5 outside the pawn chain and White has completed Nc3.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 Bf5 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nh4 Bg6 7. Nxg6 hxg6 8. Qc2 Bd6 9. g3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The bishop is Black's proudest Slav piece. White challenges it because the exchange changes the kingside pawn structure and removes control of e4. After ...hxg6, Black gains an open h-file and central support from the g-pawn, so the structure is not simply weak. White uses Qc2, Bd3 or g3, and a timely e4. King safety determines whether castling short is comfortable or whether the h-file demands extra care.

White's plan

- After ...hxg6, watch the h-file before castling and consider g3 to blunt ...Bxh2 ideas.
- Use e4 when Nf3, Nc3, and the queen support it; the missing light bishop makes central expansion stronger.
- Target e6 or c6 only after development; Black's doubled g-pawns can also control useful squares.

What Black is trying to do

- The open h-file may create a direct attack against a castled king.
- ...Bd6 and ...Qc7 can threaten ...Bxh2 or ...e5.
- ...e5 is often Black's liberating break and may be supported by the g-pawn on g6 controlling f5.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Bg6	7.Nxg6 hxg6. Accept that Black gains the h-file; exploit the bishop pair and e4.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Bc8	The bishop has lost tempi; continue Bd3 and O-O without chasing it again.
6...Be4	7.f3 asks the bishop again but weakens e3; use only when ...Bg6 leaves no tactic.
...Bd6	Decide whether Bxd6 removes Black's best piece or whether keeping Bd3 helps e4.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The exchange on g6 is a trade, not a free win: White gains the bishop pair and structural targets; Black gains a rook file and central squares.

MEMORY HOOK

Take the bishop, then respect the h-file and strike with e4.

CHAPTER 03

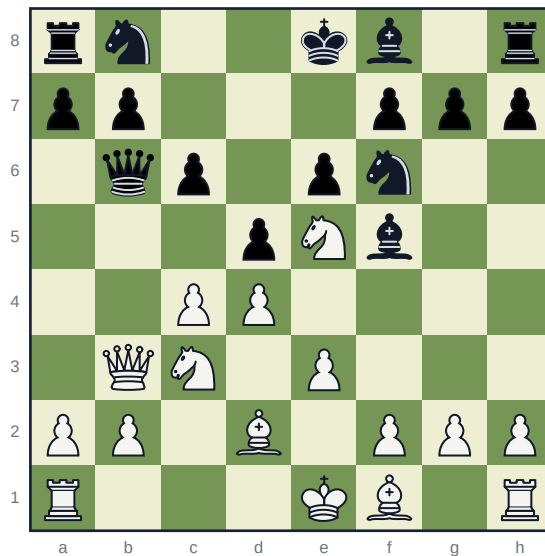
Black chooses ...Bg4

POSITION TRIGGER

Instead of ...Bf5, Black pins Nf3 with ...Bg4.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 Bg4 5. Qb3 Qb6 6. Ne5 Bf5 7. Nc3 e6 8. Bd2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The pin changes the normal development order. Qb3 attacks b7 and asks Black to spend a tempo defending it. Ne5 centralizes the knight and sidesteps doubled f-pawns if Black exchanges on f3. White develops Nc3 and Bd2, then chooses between f3/e4 and quiet development. The position is about using the queen's early activity without letting it become a target.

White's plan

- Use Qb3 to pressure b7 and d5 while Black's queen or pieces are awkwardly placed.
- Centralize Ne5 when it cannot be driven away favorably by ...Nbd7 or ...e6.
- Finish Nc3, Bd2, and Rc1; use e4 only after checking the pin and d4 pressure.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Qb6 offers a queen trade and reinforces d4/c5 squares.
- ...Nbd7 challenges Ne5 and may prepare ...e5.
- ...e6 can transpose into a Semi-Slav with the bishop already outside the chain.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Bg4	5.Qb3 creates a concrete reply instead of passively accepting the pin.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...Qb6	6.Ne5. Keep queens unless a trade improves development.
...Nbd7	Nxd7 can remove a defender; otherwise complete development and let the knight retreat.
...Bxf3	Recapture Qxf3 when possible; gxf3 is acceptable only for center and bishop-pair compensation.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Qb3 is effective because c2 is clear after c4. If another move order leaves c2 occupied or b7 tactically defended, use Be2 instead of forcing the pattern.

MEMORY HOOK

Pin on f3: pressure b7, centralize e5, then complete development.

CHAPTER 04

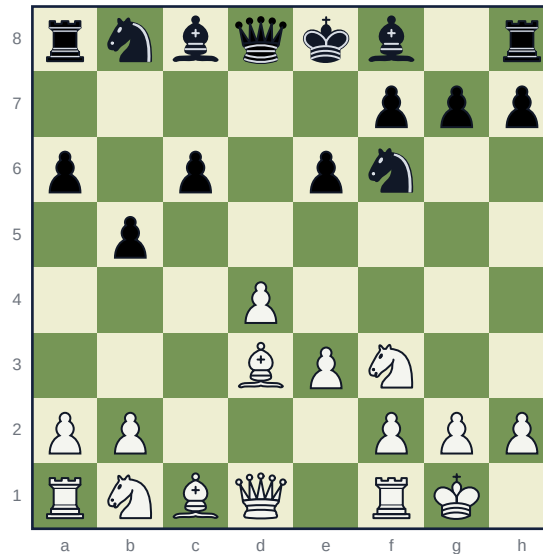
Chebanenko Slav with ...a6

POSITION TRIGGER

Black inserts ...a6 to prepare ...b5 and flexible queenside expansion.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 a6 5. Bd3 dxc4 6. Bxc4 b5 7. Bd3 e6 8. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The move ...a6 makes Black's queenside expansion more credible but delays central development. White develops Bd3 and answers ...dxc4 with Bxc4. After ...b5, retreat Bd3 and prepare a4 or e4 according to the center. Opening the center is attractive while Black's king is uncastled, but only if White's own king is safe.

White's plan

- Recover c4 with the bishop and allow ...b5 only when the retreat gains a target on the queenside.
- Use a4 to challenge b5 when exchanges expose a6 or c6.
- Use e4 when Black has spent enough time on ...a6 and ...b5 that central opening favors White's lead in development.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b5 gains space and can support ...Bb7.
- ...dxc4 may draw the bishop to c4 so ...b5 gains a tempo.
- ...e6 and ...c5 can return to a solid center after queenside expansion.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...a6	5.Bd3 develops and prepares castling.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...dxc4	6.Bxc4. Regain naturally; do not use queen moves to save a tempo.
6...b5	7.Bd3 and later a4 if it creates a concrete weakness.
...Bg4	Use Qc2 or Nbd2 to break the pin before e4.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not play a4 merely because ...b5 appeared. Calculate axb5 cxb5 and decide whether the opened a- or c-file helps your pieces.

MEMORY HOOK

Black spends wing tempi; recover, castle, and challenge center or b5.

CHAPTER 05

Anti-Meran with 5.b3

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6: Black has chosen the Semi-Slav.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. b3 Nbd7 6. Bb2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The b3 system develops the dark bishop before Black's ...dxc4 and ...b5 can gain too much space. It avoids the most forcing Meran and Botvinnik theory while retaining the central e4 break. White accepts that b3 is a tempo and a slight dark-square concession in exchange for a stable setup whose plans repeat. The bishop on b2 pressures e5 and supports central expansion.

White's plan

- Develop Bb2, Bd3, O-O, and Nbd2 or Nc3 according to Black's pressure on d4.
- Prepare e4 with Qc2 and Nbd2 when the b2 bishop makes the break tactically sound.
- If Black captures c4, recover bxc4 only when it opens the b-file usefully; Bxc4 is usually simpler.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Bd6 prepares ...O-O and ...e5 while eyeing h2.
- ...b6 and ...Bb7 mirror White's bishop and reinforce the center.
- ...dxc4 followed by ...b5 can still gain queenside space if White delays recovery.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...e6	5.b3 establishes the Anti-Meran identity.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...Nbd7	6.Bb2 Bd6 7.Bd3 and castle.
5...Bb4+	6.Bd2 Bd6 7.Bd3; block with development, not a weakening pawn move.
5...b6	6.Bb2 Bb7 7.Bd3; prepare the center and watch ...Nbd7-e4.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not rush e4 while Nf3 is pinned or d4 is underloaded. The setup earns a good break; it does not make the break automatic.

MEMORY HOOK

b3 frees the bishop; Bb2 and Bd3 build e4.

CHAPTER 06

Semi-Slav central break

POSITION TRIGGER

Both sides have completed the basic Anti-Meran setup and Black is ready for ...e5 or ...c5.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. b3 Nbd7 6. Bb2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O b6 9. Nbd2 Bb7 10. Qc2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The central question is whether White can play e4 without losing d4 or allowing a tactical shot on h2. Nbd2 and Qc2 support e4; the b2 bishop increases pressure on e5. If Black plays ...e5 first, dxe5 can open lines while Nxe5 permits a central outpost. If Black plays ...c5, White decides whether to preserve tension or exchange into an isolated-pawn structure.

White's plan

- Prepare e4 with Nbd2 and Qc2; check the h2 diagonal before moving the f-pawn or center.
- Against ...e5, calculate dxe5 and Nxe5 rather than reacting by habit.
- Against ...c5, compare cxd5, dxc5, and maintaining tension by which side gains activity.

What Black is trying to do

- ...e5 is Black's ideal freeing break and may create a kingside initiative.
- ...c5 attacks d4 and can isolate White's central pawn.
- ...Ne4 centralizes a knight and may combine with ...f5 if White is slow.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...e5	Test dxe5 Nxe5 and whether Nxe5 wins central space or exposes h2.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...c5	Reclassify the structure before choosing a wing plan.
...Ne4	Challenge the knight with Nxe4 or f3 only after checking the b8-h2 diagonal.
...Qe7	Expect ...e5 and tactics on h2; complete the central support.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The bishop on b2 is powerful only if the center opens. If Black blocks it, improve the worst piece and prepare the break instead of admiring the diagonal.

MEMORY HOOK

Build Nbd2-Qc2, then earn e4.

CHAPTER 07

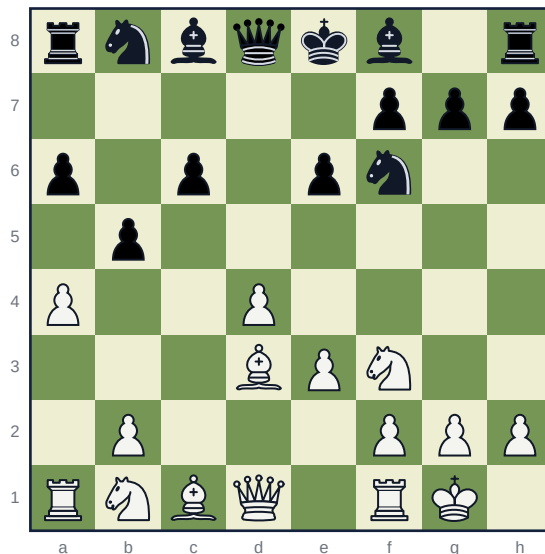
Black captures on c4

POSITION TRIGGER

Black releases the d5 tension with ...dxc4 before or after ...e6.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 dxc4 5. Bxc4 b5 6. Bd3 a6 7. O-O e6 8. a4



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White's move order makes recovery simple: e3 opens the bishop, and Bxc4 develops while regaining the pawn. Black's ...b5 gains a tempo and space, but it can also create a fixed queenside target. White castles, then uses a4 if exchanges expose a6/c6 or uses e4 if the center can be opened first. The bishop should retreat to d3, where it supports e4 and points toward h7.

White's plan

- Recover with Bxc4 unless a central e4 move gives a stronger tactical reason to delay.
- Retreat Bd3 after ...b5 and castle before starting a4 or e4.
- Use a4 when axb5 creates an open file or a backward pawn; use e4 when development is the larger advantage.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b5 gains a tempo and supports the extra space with ...a6.
- ...Bg4 can pin Nf3 before White plays e4.
- ...e6 and ...c5 may liquidate the queenside weaknesses through central activity.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...dxc4	5.Bxc4 is the point of 4.e3.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...b5	6.Bd3. Preserve the bishop's central role.
...a6	Castle, then consider a4; do not open files with the king in the center.
...Bg4	Use Qc2 or Nbd2 and break the pin before committing e4.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Trying to save a tempo with a4 before castling can let ...Bb7 and ...c5 open the center against White's king.

MEMORY HOOK

Recover by development; castle; then undermine b5 or open the center.

CHAPTER 08

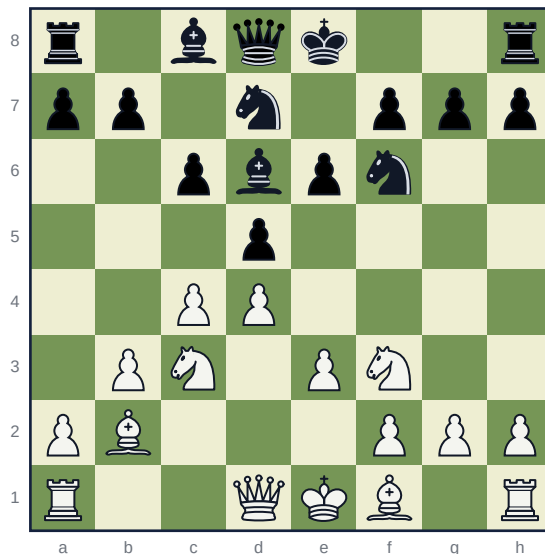
Triangle move orders

POSITION TRIGGER

Black reaches ...d5, ...e6, and ...c6 before declaring a Slav or Semi-Slav move order.

Your anchor line

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. b3 Nbd7 6. Bb2 Bd6 7. e3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The Triangle can tempt White into sharp Noteboom theory after an early ...dxc4. This repertoire uses Nf3 and the same b3/Bb2 logic, accepting QGA-style recovery if Black captures. If ...f5 appears, classify the Stonewall and use g3/Bg2 or b3/Bb2 according to the locked center. The exact order matters because White has already committed Nc3 rather than e3.

White's plan

- Use Nf3 to support the center and prepare e3 without entering a forced pawn chase.
- If ...Nf6 follows, use b3 and transpose to the Anti-Meran setup.
- If ...dxc4 comes first, use e3 and recover Bxc4; challenge ...b5 with a4 after castling.

What Black is trying to do

- ...dxc4 and ...b5 may try to hold the pawn in Noteboom style.
- ...f5 creates a Stonewall center and closes the light bishop.
- ...Nf6 returns to a normal Semi-Slav with Nc3 already developed.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...c6	4.Nf3 keeps the repertoire flexible.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Nf6	5.b3 and use the Anti-Meran plan.
4...dxc4	5.e3 b5 6.a4, combining recovery with immediate pressure.
4...f5	5.g3 Nf6 6.Bg2 Bd6 7.O-O; attack the Stonewall's dark squares.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not play 4.e4 automatically: Black's Triangle exists partly to punish an overextended center through ...dxe4 and ...e5 ideas.

MEMORY HOOK

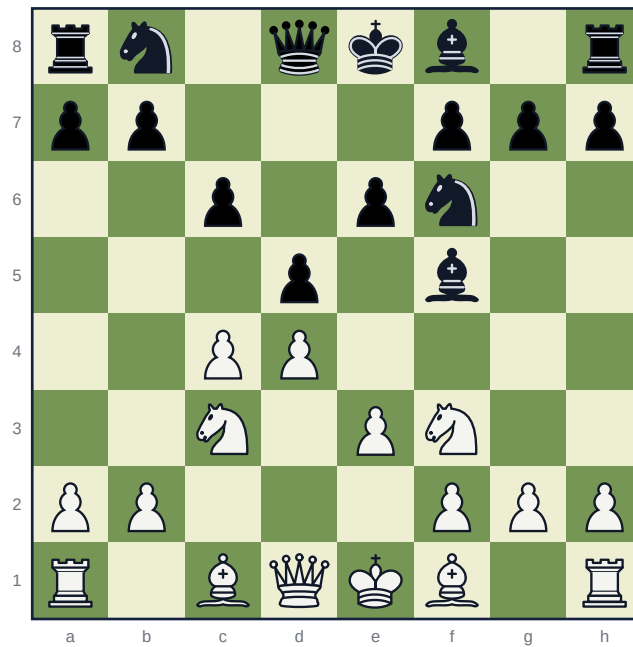
Triangle: Nf3 first; then b3 if solid, e3 if captured, g3 if ...f5.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | Challenge the bishop

What is the repertoire move, and what structural bargain follows if Black retreats normally?



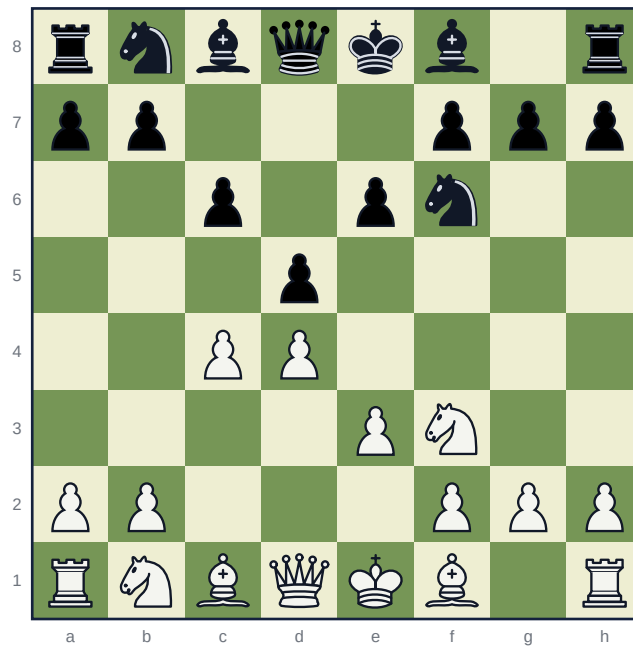
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 Bf5 5. Nc3 e6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | Semi-Slav identity

Which setup avoids the sharpest Meran memory battle while retaining a central plan?



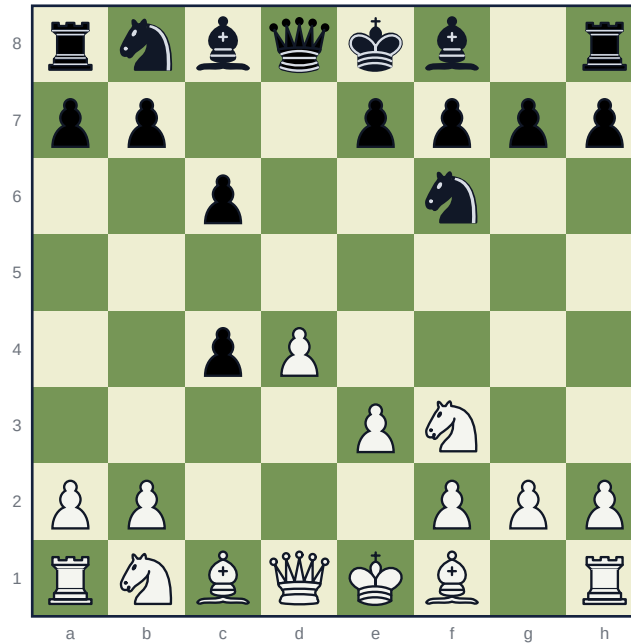
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Recover without drama

How does the move order make pawn recovery efficient?



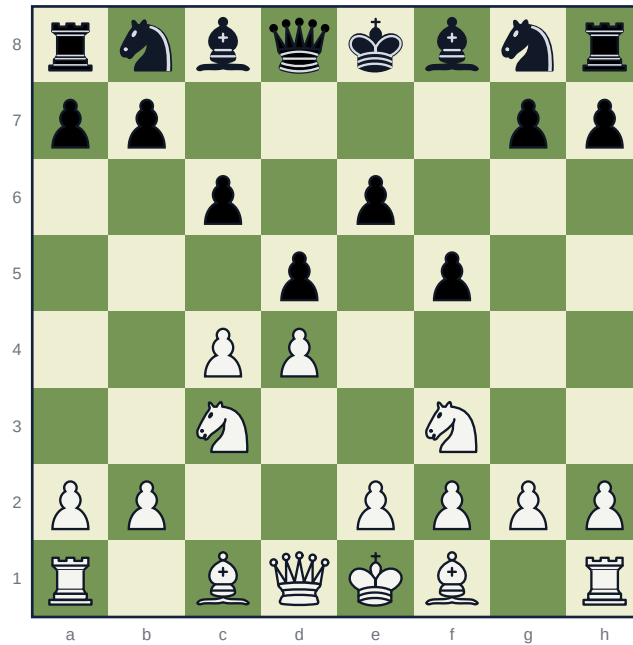
Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 dxc4

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Triangle classification

Which structural family has Black created, and what development plan replaces the Anti-Meran?



Position reached by: 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c6 4. Nf3 f5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | Challenge the bishop

Play 6.Nh4. After 6...Bg6 7.Nxg6 hxg6, White gains the bishop pair and easier e4 control; Black gains an open h-file and useful central squares. Continue Bd3, Qc2, and castle with awareness of the h-file.

TEST 02 | Semi-Slav identity

Use 5.b3, followed by Bb2, Bd3, O-O, and Nbd2/Qc2. The system aims for e4 after sufficient preparation.

TEST 03 | Recover without drama

Play 5.Bxc4. The bishop develops while recovering the pawn. If ...b5 gains a tempo, retreat Bd3, castle, and later challenge the queenside with a4 or the center with e4.

TEST 04 | Triangle classification

This is a Stonewall-style center. Use 5.g3 Nf6 6.Bg2 Bd6 7.O-O, then attack dark squares and prepare Bf4 or Ne5. The center's closure makes the fianchetto more relevant than b3/Bb2.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6: Black supports d5 without enclosing the c8 bishop.	Nf3 and e3 build; Nc3 makes Nh4 safe; then ask the bishop.
Black has developed Bf5 outside the pawn chain and White has completed Nc3.	Take the bishop, then respect the h-file and strike with e4.
Instead of ...Bf5, Black pins Nf3 with ...Bg4.	Pin on f3: pressure b7, centralize e5, then complete development.
Black inserts ...a6 to prepare ...b5 and flexible queenside expansion.	Black spends wing tempi; recover, castle, and challenge center or b5.
1.d4 d5 2.c4 c6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.e3 e6: Black has chosen the Semi-Slav.	b3 frees the bishop; Bb2 and Bd3 build e4.
Both sides have completed the basic Anti-Meran setup and Black is ready for ...e5 or ...c5.	Build Nbd2-Qc2, then earn e4.
Black releases the d5 tension with ...dxc4 before or after ...e6.	Recover by development; castle; then undermine b5 or open the center.
Black reaches ...d5, ...e6, and ...c6 before declaring a Slav or Semi-Slav move order.	Triangle: Nf3 first; then b3 if solid, e3 if captured, g3 if ...f5.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.